



MAREC INSIGHTS | OCTOBER 2026 EDITION

Luxury Resort Workforce Intelligence Report

The 2026 numbers behind hotel and resort performance - and where labor strategy is deciding who keeps the margin.

Mark Anthony Recio, MBA | marec.site | mark.recio@marec.site | (702) 763-2573



EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Record demand, rising costs: 2026 rewards operators who manage labor well

U.S. hotels are having a strong 2026. In its August forecast, CoStar (STR) and Tourism Economics raised full-year U.S. RevPAR growth to **+4.4%**, after the industry sold a record number of room nights in the first half, helped by the FIFA World Cup and America 250 events. Luxury is leading, and Caribbean resorts have posted year-over-year occupancy gains in every month reported through July.

But revenue is not the same as profit. AHLA reports that U.S. hotel labor costs rose **15.3%** from 2019 to 2025, outpacing **12.8%** growth in operating revenue, and that gross operating profit per available room is still only about 90% of 2019 levels. The same forecasters expect RevPAR growth to slow to about +2.1% in 2027, so cost discipline matters more as the event tailwind fades.

+4.4%

U.S. RevPAR growth
forecast for 2026
(CoStar/STR, Aug 2026)

73.4%

Caribbean hotel occupancy,
Jan-Jul 2026, up 5.4% YoY
(STR)

15.3%

Hotel labor cost growth
2019-2025 vs. 12.8%
revenue growth (AHLA)

"Demand is not the problem in 2026. Converting demand into profit is."

How to read this report

Sections 1-3 use published 2026 data from CoStar/STR, Tourism Economics, AHLA and other cited sources (full list on the last page). Section 4 shows the analytics and workforce services that operators are prioritizing in response, and how Marec Insights delivers them.

Section	What you will learn
1. The 2026 market	U.S. and Caribbean performance, and what is driving it
2. The labor squeeze	Costs, shortages and what hoteliers are doing about it
3. Six trends shaping resorts	Luxury, events, AI, wellness, workforce and Caribbean momentum
4. Services hotels are seeking	Analytics, revenue management, data science and workforce analytics - and how Marec Insights delivers them
5. 90-day action plan	How to start, plus how to reach Marec Insights

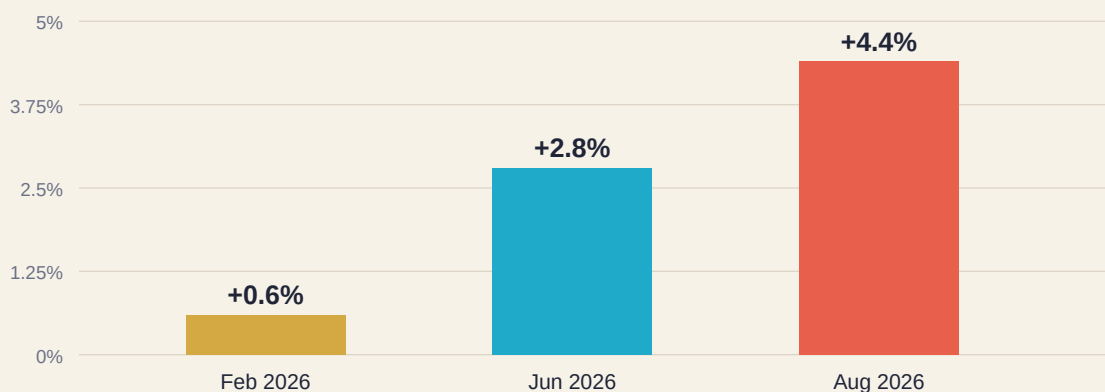


SECTION 1

The 2026 market: strong, event-fueled and luxury-led

The forecast has been revised upward twice this year as results beat expectations. CoStar and Tourism Economics started 2026 at +0.6% U.S. RevPAR growth (February), moved to +2.8% in June, and reached +4.4% in August.

U.S. full-year 2026 RevPAR growth forecast, by release date



Source: CoStar/STR and Tourism Economics U.S. Hotel Forecast Assumptions (Feb, Q2 and Q3 2026).

Indicator	2026 data point	Source
U.S. RevPAR growth (full year, forecast)	+4.4%; 2027 expected to slow to +2.1%	CoStar/STR, Tourism Economics
U.S. occupancy and ADR (forecast)	Occupancy 63.1%; ADR +3.1%	Hotel Dive, citing CoStar/TE
First-half room nights	Record; up 11.4 million vs. 2025	Hotel Dive, STR
Luxury chain scale	Double-digit RevPAR growth forecast in Q2 and Q3	CoStar/STR, Aug 2026
New U.S. supply growth (2026)	Only +0.4%	CoStar/TE, Q2 forecast
Caribbean occupancy, Jan-Jul	73.4%, up 5.4% YoY; March peak 80.5%	STR via Caribbean Journal

What it means

Resorts are earning more per room and filling more rooms, with limited new supply. That is a favorable setup, and it is also when labor inefficiency is most expensive: peaks demand overtime and agency labor, while shoulder periods tempt operators to leave rosters unchanged.



SECTION 2

The labor squeeze: costs up, shortages persist

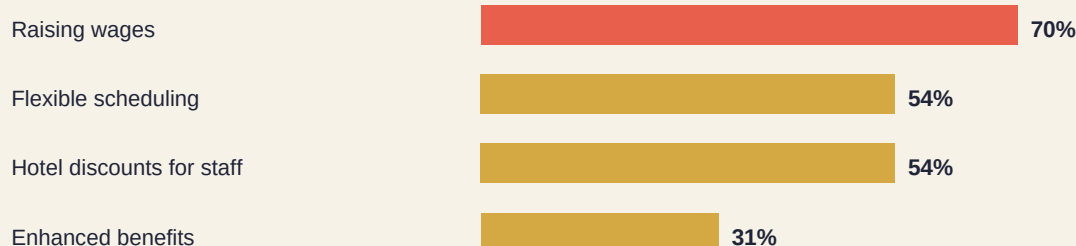
AHLA estimates U.S. hotels paid nearly \$128 billion in wages and benefits in 2025, approaching \$131 billion in 2026, with direct hotel employment growing by more than 30,000 jobs to about 2.2 million. Labor-related expenses now exceed 32% of total hotel revenue.

Top financial pressures cited by hotel owners, early 2026 (% of respondents)



Source: AHLA Front Desk Feedback survey, February/March 2026 (246 hotel owners and operators).

How hotels are responding to staffing pressure (% of surveyed hotels)



Source: AHLA, 2026. Survey also found more than half of owners still understaffed despite higher pay.

Where the gaps are: in AHLA and Hireology research, housekeeping was the most-cited shortage (38% of hotels), followed by front desk (26%). Industry turnover is commonly cited at 70-80% annually, versus roughly 12-15% in other industries. Wages alone are not solving the shortage - which is why scheduling, cross-training and retention are becoming margin strategies.

Source: AHLA/Hireology survey (Dec 2024-Jan 2025), the most recent department-level breakdown; AHLA 2026 State of the Industry.



SECTION 3

Six trends shaping hotels and resorts in 2026

1. A two-speed market: luxury leads

Premium properties are driving growth while economy segments face pressure. Travelers are taking fewer trips but spending more per trip, supporting higher rates for luxury and upper-upscale resorts that deliver distinctive experiences. (PwC; Hospitality Net; CoStar/STR)

2. Events are lifting demand - and masking costs

The FIFA World Cup and America 250 celebrations helped U.S. hotels beat forecasts in the first half. Forecasters expect growth to moderate in 2027, so event-driven revenue should not set permanent staffing levels. (Hotel Dive; CoStar/STR)

3. Labor cost growth is outpacing revenue

Since 2019 labor costs have grown faster than revenue, keeping profit per room near 90% of 2019 levels. Flexible scheduling and cross-training are now standard retention and efficiency tools. (AHLA)

4. AI becomes operational infrastructure

Beyond chatbots, hotels use AI for demand forecasting, dynamic pricing, maintenance scheduling and staffing forecasts, and to build guest profiles that power personalization. The aim is to free teams for high-touch service, not to replace them. (Hospitality Net; FCS; PwC)

5. Wellness and personalization define luxury

Wellness is moving from spa add-on to a design principle across sleep, air quality, lighting and dining. Preferred Hotels & Resorts calls cognitive wellness a defining 2026 theme, and personalization is widely cited as the top guest-experience trend. (Hospitality Net; Luxury Travel Magazine)

6. Caribbean resort momentum

After a soft 2025, regional occupancy has risen year over year in every month through July 2026, with luxury destinations such as Anguilla posting strong revenue growth. New supply in some markets will test airlift and pricing discipline. (STR via Caribbean Journal; Travel And Tour World)



SECTION 4

The services hotels and resorts are seeking in 2026

The data in this report points to one conclusion: with revenue strong and costs rising faster, operators are looking for **analytics they can act on**. Industry coverage shows AI and data science moving into everyday operations - pricing, demand forecasting, guest segmentation and staffing forecasts - while labor cost control has become a board-level priority. **Marec Insights** delivers exactly these services, built as working models (Python, R, SQL, Power BI, Tableau) before engagement begins - no slideware.

What the market is seeking in 2026	Marec Insights service	What you get
Control of labor costs growing faster than revenue (AHLA: +15.3% vs. +12.8%)	Workforce and HR analytics	Overtime-leakage diagnostics, staffing curves for peak and shoulder periods, automated scheduling rules
Pricing power in a luxury-led market; AI-driven dynamic pricing	Revenue management and pricing	RevPAR and ADR optimization, booking pace and seasonality mix, group pace and space utility
AI for demand and staffing forecasting	Data science and forecasting	Predictive demand models and Monte Carlo simulation on your PMS, POS and payroll data
Personalization at scale for luxury guests	Guest experience analytics	Sentiment and service-recovery metrics tied to staffing and service levels
Data-backed decisions for owners, GMs and asset managers	Hospitality analytics and executive BI	Power BI / Tableau reporting loops and dashboards with one version of the truth

Source: Market needs drawn from AHLA, CoStar/STR, PwC, Hospitality Net and FCS Hub (see sources). Service descriptions from Marec Insights.

Four-stage approach: descriptive baseline (PMS, POS, payroll) > diagnostic (overtime and labor leakage) > predictive (peak and shoulder staffing simulations) > prescriptive (scheduling rules that protect margin).

Proof, not promises

Live demo: a resort analytics app combining booking pace, Monte Carlo simulation and a Labor Efficiency Ratio. **Board briefing:** a convention-hotel revenue leakage framework with loss-recovery segmentation.

Interactive hub: BI dashboards, simulation tools and yield calculators at markrecipro.github.io/Portfolio.

Low-risk 30-day pilot

1. 20-minute call to confirm scope and fit. **2. Data readiness audit** at a low fee. **3. 30-day working-model pilot:** a custom dashboard or simulation built on your data, under NDA with a read-only CSV/Excel export bridge.



SECTION 5

Your 90-day action plan

Phase	Focus	Outcome
Days 1-30	Baseline: pull 12 months of occupancy, payroll, overtime and schedule data	A clear picture of labor-hour gaps by department
Days 31-60	Pilot: demand-based rosters in housekeeping and front desk	Early validation and team feedback
Days 61-90	Scale: extend to F&B; and spa, set KPI dashboard	Repeatable process and tracked savings

Schedule an Executive Consultation

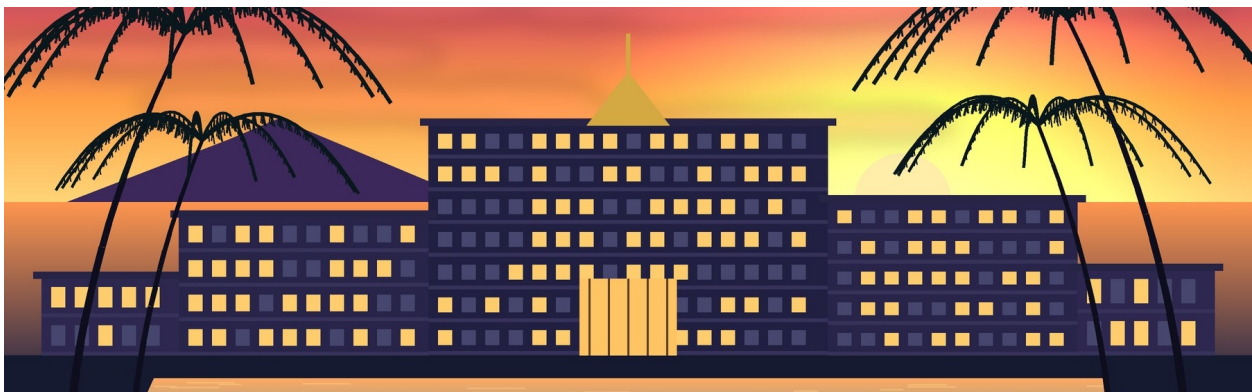
Can we discuss how this applies to your property? Marec Insights offers a complimentary, no-obligation review of your labor-utilization picture, tailored to your resort or portfolio.



NAME Mark Anthony Recio, MBA
PHONE (702) 763-2573
EMAIL mark.recio@marec.site
WEBSITE marec.site
LINKEDIN linkedin.com/in/marecio

Who should read this

Resort and hotel general managers, owners, asset managers, management companies and hospitality recruiters who want a data-driven view of 2026 performance and workforce strategy.





SOURCES

Sources and notes

1. CoStar/STR and Tourism Economics, "U.S. Hotel Forecast Assumptions" - Q2 2026 (June 1, 2026) and Q3/August 2026 (costar.com; hospitalitynet.org).
2. Hotel Dive, "CoStar, Tourism Economics 'significantly' boost US hotel outlook" (2026) - 4.4% RevPAR, 63.1% occupancy, ADR +3.1%, record first-half room nights.
3. CoStar/STR, "Hotel Forecast Assumptions - February 2026" - initial +0.6% RevPAR forecast.
4. American Hotel & Lodging Association (AHLA), "2026 State of the Industry" (ahla.com) - wages and benefits, employment, GOPPAR, labor vs. revenue growth.
5. Hotel Dive, "Top 5 hospitality industry trends to watch in 2026" - labor costs up 15.3% (2019-2025) vs. 12.8% revenue growth; labor above 32% of revenue.
6. AHLA Front Desk Feedback survey (Feb/Mar 2026), reported by MarketScale, Hotel-Online and Hospitality Net - owner pressures and recruiting incentives.
7. AHLA and Hireology survey (Dec 2024-Jan 2025), reported by Lodging Magazine - 38% housekeeping and 26% front desk shortages.
8. Caribbean Journal, citing STR - Caribbean hotel occupancy 2026 (published Aug 18, 2026).
9. Travel And Tour World, citing STR Caribbean Hotel Performance Report (YTD May 2026).
10. Hospitality Net, "What's Next for Hospitality in 2026?" and "The Hotels Leading the Industry in 2026"; PwC/ULI Emerging Trends in Real Estate, Hospitality outlook; Luxury Travel Magazine; FCS Hub.

Notes: Statistics are as published by the named sources and are current as of early October 2026; forecasts may be revised. The turnover range of 70-80% is as reported in industry coverage of AHLA research. This report is for informational purposes and is not financial or legal advice.